

CERT-In Advisory on Malicious Android APKs and Remote Access Trojans

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Official Source: <https://www.cert-in.org.in/advisories/security-advisory-malicious-apk-apps.pdf>

Official Advisory: CERT-In Advisory CIAD-2024: Threat Posed by Sideloaded APK Malware

Threat Overview: Banking Trojans and RATs

Indian Computer Emergency Response Team (CERT-In) has detected sophisticated campaigns distributing malicious Android APK files disguised as banking customer support utilities, electricity bill verifiers, courier trackers, or wedding invitation cards. Prominent malware families include SharkBot, SOVA, Anatsa, and Hydra RAT.

Exploitation of Accessibility Services and SMS Permissions

Upon installation, the malicious app requests Accessibility Services, SMS read/receive permissions, and Notification Listener access. With accessibility access enabled, the malware performs keylogging, intercepts incoming 2FA OTPs, suppresses incoming fraud alert notifications, and initiates automated wire transfers in the background while the user's screen is locked.

Essential Remediation and Preventive Measures

1. Ensure 'Install from Unknown Sources' remains disabled in your Android security settings.
2. Never download APK files sent over WhatsApp, SMS, or Telegram channels.
3. Inspect requested application permissions; financial apps never require accessibility service rights or call-forwarding control.
4. Utilize Google Play Protect and reputable on-device antivirus scanners (such as M-Kavach 2 developed by C-DAC).

Immediate Incident Handling

If you suspect an unauthorized APK has been installed: immediately toggle Airplane Mode, uninstall the suspicious app, run an antivirus scan, contact your bank from a secondary device to freeze netbanking access, and factory reset the compromised smartphone.

Citizen Action Checklist & Red Flags

- **Verify Sender Identity:** Always check official website addresses and header IDs (e.g., VM-SBI, AX-HDFC). Scammers use fake sender masks.
- **Never Share Authentication Secrets:** Passwords, OTPs, UPI PINs, and debit card CVVs are strictly confidential. Bank staff will NEVER ask for them.
- **Independent Verification:** If you receive a threat or alert about an account freeze, call the official bank branch number found on your physical card or bank statement.
- **Immediate Reporting:** Report cyber financial fraud within the Golden Hour by calling 1930 or visiting cybercrime.gov.in.

Frequently Asked Questions (Regulatory Clarifications)

Q1: Can money be deposited into my bank account by entering my UPI PIN?

A: No. A UPI PIN is solely an authorization to debit funds from your linked bank account. Receiving funds requires NO authentication or PIN entry.

Q2: What is the first action to take if money is fraudulently deducted?

A: Dial 1930 immediately to register the complaint on the Indian Cybercrime Coordination Centre (I4C) CFCFRMS portal so that the beneficiary account can be frozen before funds are withdrawn.

Q3: What should I do if an unknown caller threatens me with a police arrest over video call?

A: Disconnect immediately. Indian police and law enforcement agencies never issue summons, conduct investigations, or

place citizens under 'Digital Arrest' via video calls.

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